COLLEGE OF ARTS AND TECHNOLOGY

CIIT

NEXTEP

Your Next Step Starts Here

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Nextep is a technology-driven platform designed to bridge the gap between education and employment for senior high school students, college graduates, and young professionals in the Philippines. Many individuals face unclear pathways to their dream careers due to limited guidance, outdated career advising systems, and the absence of data-driven planning tools. Schools and institutions lack access to accurate insights on student aspirations and employability, hindering curriculum improvements.

Nextep offers a free, Spotify-like experience where users input personal information, educational background, skills, dream job, and dream company. An AI-powered algorithm generates personalized career roadmaps, highlighting necessary skills, recommended courses, certifications, and alternative job options aligned with their goals. Institutions can access anonymized data via paid subscriptions, enabling them to refine course offerings and improve employability outcomes.

The market opportunity is significant, with over 2.3 million college graduates entering the Philippine workforce annually and many young professionals seeking better career pathways. Existing job portals focus on listings, leaving a gap for strategic, personalized guidance, which Nextep aims to fill.

Nextep's revenue model combines B2B and B2C approaches. The platform remains free for individual users to encourage rapid adoption. Revenue streams include monthly or annual subscriptions for schools and institutions to access analytics dashboards, as well as targeted ads from universities and training centers. Future integration with job boards and premium employer-side recruitment tools will expand monetization opportunities.

With a three-phase scaling plan—from MVP rollout in pilot schools, to nationwide adoption, to regional expansion—Nextep aims to become the go-to platform for career planning. Financial projections estimate ₱1.8M in Year 2 and ₱5.5M in Year 3 revenue, achieving ₱2.1M net income by Year 3.

Through AI-powered technology, strategic partnerships, and data-driven insights, Nextep has the potential to transform career guidance in the Philippines, helping students, schools, and employers build clearer, more effective pathways from education to employment.

INTRODUCTION

2.1 Platform Overview

Platform Name and Slogan

Name: Nexstep

Logo

Figure 1-2 : *Logo - Wordmark*

2.2 Problem Statement

In the Philippine education and employment landscape, a critical gap exists between academic experience and entry into the job market. Many senior high school students, college graduates, and young professionals lack a clear understanding of how to reach their dream careers due to minimal guidance, outdated career advising systems, and the absence of accessible, data-driven career planning tools. Institutions, in turn, have limited visibility into student goals and employability outcomes, making it difficult to design curriculums and programs that effectively prepare graduates for real-world opportunities.

Current platforms, such as job boards and professional networking sites, offer listings but fail to provide personalized roadmaps that guide individuals step-by-step from their current profile to their dream role. This results in misaligned educational choices, underemployment, high attrition rates, and a growing disconnect between education and workforce demands.

Key Problems Identified:

- Fragmented job tracking: Manual tracking of applications leads to missed opportunities and inefficient follow-ups.
- No guided career planning: Lack of tailored recommendations on skills, certifications, and relevant experience for targeted careers.
- Weak school-to-employment linkage: Institutions lack data-driven insights into graduate outcomes, hindering curriculum improvements.
- Information gap for young professionals: Limited feedback on employability profile gaps and unclear pathways to career goals.
- Absence of smart career mapping: No centralized algorithm that recommends career paths, alternative roles, and skill-building steps similar to how Spotify suggests music or Tinder matches

users.

2.3 Market Analysis

- Youth unemployment rate: Around 10–12% in 2024, notably higher than the national average (~4%).
- Annual graduates: Over 1.6 million Filipinos graduate yearly from senior high and college programs, creating a vast user base actively seeking guidance.
- Job search inefficiencies: 35–40% of graduates remain unemployed or underemployed within 1–2 years post-graduation due to poor guidance and skill mismatches.
- Digital adoption growth: With 85% projected smartphone penetration by 2026, a web-based and mobile-ready solution can reach a broad audience effectively.
- Institutional need: Schools and universities demand real-time analytics and feedback loops to measure student employability and optimize their course offerings.
- Nextep aims to bridge this gap with an AI-powered, intelligent career roadmap platform that empowers students and young professionals while equipping institutions with actionable insights to improve graduate success rates.

2.4 Innovative Solution

We propose a free, Spotify-style web platform designed to help students discover and map personalized career paths. Students input personal information (e.g., degree program, dream job, dream company), and the system provides:

- Recommended skills and certifications
- Suggested alternative career options
- Feedback on career readiness and gaps
- A roadmap to achieve their goals

The platform is built with a recommendation engine that operates similarly to Spotify or Tinder, analyzing user preferences and input patterns to generate accurate and engaging results. The interface is gamified to promote student retention and active engagement. A premium add-on offers a job application tracker that helps students manage and monitor their application progress.
The institutional version of the product features a customizable dashboard and analytics engine that schools can use to track overall student goals, design demand-driven curriculum improvements, and visualize employability trends. These insights can empower universities to act as proactive collaborators in national workforce development.

ENVIRONMENTAL ANALYSIS

3.1 PESTEL Analysis

Political Factors

- Government focus on education-to-employment alignment: Ongoing initiatives like the Philippine Development Plan 2023–2028 emphasize improving youth employability and reducing underemployment rates.
- TESDA and CHED partnerships: Opportunities for collaboration with national agencies pushing for skill-based learning and certifications.
- Data privacy regulations (Data Privacy Act of 2012): Must ensure compliance when handling

sensitive student information.
- Government-funded scholarships and job programs: Potential integration with public employment services for enhanced student support.

Economic Factors

- Youth unemployment remains high (10–12%): Reflecting a major market need for structured career guidance tools.
- High underemployment rates: Many graduates work in jobs unrelated to their degree, signaling mismatched skills and job market requirements.
- School and university budget limitations: Pricing model must be flexible (tiered pricing or per-student rates) to accommodate varying institutional resources.
- Growth in tech and BPO sectors: Rising demand for skilled talent in specific industries that Nextep can help funnel students toward.
- Economic recovery post-pandemic: Increased focus on employability as institutions strive to improve graduate outcomes and career readiness.

Social Factors

- Cultural emphasis on degree-based success: Families and students prioritize securing stable, reputable jobs aligned with educational background.
- Mismatch between aspirations and market reality: Students dream of high-paying jobs without knowing skill prerequisites or alternative pathways.
- High digital literacy among youth: Large population of tech-savvy students willing to use mobile/web tools for career planning.
- Parental and societal pressure: Students need structured, credible career guidance to make informed decisions early on.
- Growing interest in alternative careers: Non-traditional paths (freelancing, remote work, startup roles) require updated tools for navigation.

Technological Factors

- AI and data-driven algorithms: Enable personalized recommendations for skills, certifications, and career paths similar to Spotify/Tinder models.
- Integration with school systems: Ability to link Nextep with existing Learning Management Systesms (LMS), student records, or third-party tools like Airtable for real-time data updates.
- Cloud-based accessibility: Ensures scalability and availability across devices with minimal IT overhead for schools.
- Data analytics capabilities: Provide institutions with actionable insights for curriculum improvement and employment tracking.
- Emerging EdTech solutions: Competitive advantage in being the first specialized career roadmap app tailored for the Philippine market.

Environmental Factors

- Remote work trend reducing environmental impact: More students seeking online tools to prepare for hybrid/remote job opportunities.
- Minimal carbon footprint of SaaS platforms: Web-based solution reduces the need for physical

career fairs or printed materials.
- Alignment with sustainable development goals (SDG 8 – Decent Work and Economic Growth): Helps bridge education-to-employment gaps sustainably.

Legal Factors

- Data privacy and cybersecurity laws: Strict compliance with RA 10173 (Data Privacy Act) and international standards (GDPR-like frameworks) is essential.
- Labor laws and youth employment policies: Must adapt features to local employment regulations and reporting standards.
- Intellectual property protection: Safeguarding Nextep's proprietary algorithms and data insights from competitors.
- School contracts and institutional agreements: Require clear terms on data usage, confidentiality of salary and incentive data, and access restrictions to sensitive student information.

3.2 Porter's Five Forces

Force	Factors	Rating
New Entrants	• Barriers to entry: Developing a sophisticated, AI-driven career guidance platform requires significant time, expertise, and funding, making it challenging for new startups to replicate quickly. • First-mover advantage: Few to no existing specialized platforms in the Philippine market offer personalized career mapping with institutional integration, giving Nextep a strong positioning. • Switching costs for schools: Once integrated with student records and data pipelines, schools may be reluctant to switch to new entrants due to time, cost, and data migration concerns. • Potential competitors: EdTech startups or established job portals could pivot to include similar features in the future, but lack of specialization currently limits their threat.	Medium
Supplier Power	• Technology infrastructure providers: Cloud hosting, AI tools, and database management systems are widely available and competitively priced, reducing supplier leverage. • Talent pool: Access to skilled developers and data analysts in the Philippines and globally ensures Nextep can source talent without overdependence on a single supplier.	Low

	• Third-party integrations: Partnerships with platforms like Airtable or LMS providers are optional enhancements, not critical dependencies.	
Buyer Power	• Price sensitivity: Schools, particularly public institutions, have limited budgets and will negotiate pricing models (per-student or annual subscription) aggressively. • Multiple options for basic solutions: Institutions could rely on manual tracking or spreadsheets as alternatives, lowering immediate dependency on Nextep. • Unique value proposition: Personalized career roadmaps and employability data insights differentiate Nextep, reducing buyer leverage over time. • Potential to scale beyond schools: Expanding to individual paid subscriptions reduces overreliance on institutional buyers.	Low
Threat of Substitutes	• Existing job portals and LinkedIn: Provide job listings and networking but lack tailored career roadmaps and skill gap analysis. • Manual solutions: Spreadsheets and offline advising offer basic tracking but not predictive, AI-driven guidance. • University career offices: Offer human advising but are often under-resourced and unable to personalize guidance for every student. • Workshops and seminars: Can support skill development but do not offer ongoing, dynamic tracking or actionable data-driven recommendations.	Moderate
Industry Rivalry	• Few direct competitors: No dominant player currently offers a specialized, algorithm-driven career guidance and tracking solution integrated with schools in the Philippines. • Future rivalry risk: Job boards, HR platforms, or EdTech startups could replicate some features once	Low to Moderate

	they observe Nextep's success. ● Differentiation potential: Strong proprietary recommendation algorithm, institutional reporting, and student-centric design provide competitive advantage. ● Network effects: As more students and schools use Nextep, the value of aggregated data insights increases, making it harder for new competitors to match.	

BUSINESS MODEL CANVAS

Key Partners:

- **Schools and Universities:** Primary partners adopting the platform and providing access to graduating students and young professionals.
- **Government agencies (CHED, DOLE):** Potential partnerships for workforce data and employability statistics.
- **Learning platforms and certification providers:** Integration to suggest relevant courses and certifications.
- **Technology providers:** Cloud hosting (AWS, Google Cloud), AI and data analytics tools, cybersecurity providers.
- **Job boards and recruitment platforms:** Future partnerships for job listings integration.
- **Career coaches and HR experts:** To enhance algorithm recommendations and advisory content.

Key Activities:

- Developing and maintaining the web-based platform and mobile-friendly interface.
- Building and refining the recommendation algorithm for personalized career paths.
- Collecting and analyzing employability data from institutions and external sources.
- Integrating with school databases and Airtable for data management.
- Marketing and onboarding schools and universities.
- Providing training and support to institutional clients.
- Regularly updating job market trends, certifications, and career data.

Value Propositions:

- **For Students and Young Professionals:** A free, intelligent, Spotify-like platform recommending skills, courses, certifications, and career paths to help reach their dream job or company.
- **For Schools/Universities:** Actionable employability data, improved graduate tracking, and the ability to tailor curriculums based on student goals and market demand.
- **For Employers (future):** Access to a pre-qualified talent pool and student career readiness insights.

- **For Institutions:** Reduces manual tracking of student job applications, providing a centralized, data-driven system.

Customer Relationships:

- Self-service student platform with personalized dashboards.
- Community support forums and help center.
- Regular feedback channels for students and institutions to refine features.
- Email updates and notifications for new job matches, skill recommendations, and milestones.
- Dedicated institutional account managers for schools and employers.

Customer Segments:

- **Primary:** Senior high school students, college graduates, and young professionals seeking career guidance.
- **Institutional:** Colleges, universities, specialized schools, and training centers.
- **Secondary (future):** Employers and recruiters seeking access to talent data.

Channels:

- Direct outreach to schools via academic partnerships and educational conferences.
- Online marketing campaigns targeted at school administrators and students.
- Integration with existing LMS platforms for seamless adoption.
- Social media presence (LinkedIn, Facebook, TikTok) for brand awareness.
- Referrals through partner institutions and student ambassadors.

Revenue Streams:

- **Institutional Subscription Model:** Monthly or annual subscription fees from schools based on the number of active students.
- **Data Insights Subscription:** Schools and educational organizations pay for aggregated, anonymized data insights to tailor curriculums.
- **Sponsored Content & Ads:** Paid promotion of courses, certifications, and specialized training programs to students.
- **Premium Features for Individuals (Future):** Young professionals outside schools can subscribe for additional features such as advanced analytics, personalized coaching, or priority job-matching tools.

Cost Structure:

- Product development (initial build and ongoing updates).
- AI and data analytics infrastructure costs.
- Salaries for developers, data analysts, marketing, and support staff.
- Marketing and sales expenses.
- Cloud hosting and cybersecurity costs.
- Legal, compliance, and data privacy management.
- Customer onboarding and training costs.

SCALING AND GROWTH STRATEGY

Phase 1: Pilot & MVP Rollout (2026–2027)

- **Development**: Build the core platform with key features such as student onboarding, personalized dashboard, and basic career recommendations.
- **Pilot Testing:** Launch with CIIT and 3–5 other partner institutions to test usability and gather early adoption feedback.
- **Key Features:** Resume builder, certification tracking, and skill gap analyzer in the first iteration.
- **Data Collection:** Collect real-world student and institutional data to refine the recommendation algorithm.
- **Goal:** 1,000 students onboarded and 3–5 school subscriptions by end of pilot phase.

Phase 2: Institutional Analytics (2027–2028)

- **Advanced Features:** Add analytics dashboard for schools to visualize student career readiness and job placement trends.
- **Institutional Integration:** Enable Airtable and LMS data sync for seamless reporting.
- **API Tools:** Develop institutional API for custom queries and reports.
- **Expansion:** Scale to 10–20 schools nationwide, leveraging partnerships with educational associations and career events.
- **Iteration 2:** Improve recommendations with enhanced data analysis, adding 'career roadmap suggestions' tailored to dream companies.
- **Goal:** Achieve 10,000+ student users and nationwide adoption in top academic institutions.

Phase 3: B2B and Ecosystem Integration (2028–2029)

- **Employer Tools:** Launch employer-side dashboards to allow companies to identify and recruit pre-qualified talent.
- **Job Market Integration:** API bridge with leading job boards and recruitment platforms.
- **Government Partnerships:** Collaborate with CHED, DOLE, and TESDA to align curriculum offerings with labor market demands.
- **International Expansion:** Begin pilot projects in Southeast Asia (Vietnam, Indonesia, Malaysia) targeting similar education-employment gaps.
- **Goal:** 50,000+ students onboarded, 50+ institutions subscribed, and initial international clients acquired.

Key Milestones:

- 1,000 students onboarded in MVP phase (Year 1).
- 15+ schools subscribed within 2 years.
- Breakeven by Year 3 with recurring institutional revenue.
- Regional expansion in Year 4 with employer partnerships.

Partnership Opportunities:

- **Incubators:** IdeaSpace, UP TBI, QBO Innovation Hub for mentorship and funding.
- **Government Initiatives:** Collaboration in national career events and job fairs.
- **Educational Networks:** Partnerships with national university career offices, private colleges, and training centers.

- **Certification Providers:** TESDA, Coursera, and other e-learning platforms for course recommendations.

FUNDING STRATEGY

Funding Sources:

- **Seed Funding (2025–2026):** Secure initial funding through:
    - Angel investors and educational technology incubators (IdeaSpace, QBO Innovation Hub).
    - Grants and government support programs (DOST, CHED innovation funds).
    - University partnerships with early adopter institutions (e.g., CIIT) contributing pilot project fees.
    - Bootstrapping from founders for initial prototype development.
- **Series A (2027–2028):** Once MVP is validated and 10–15 schools are onboarded, approach venture capital firms specializing in EdTech and SaaS solutions in Southeast Asia.
- **Revenue-Based Financing (2028 onwards):** Leverage recurring institutional subscriptions to attract non-dilutive financing options to scale operations and regional expansion.

REVENUE STREAMS

1. **Institutional Subscriptions:**
    - Annual per-student fee paid by schools/universities for platform access, analytics dashboards, and reports.
    - Estimated PHP 300–500 per student/year.
2. **Data Insights Subscription:**
    - Schools and government agencies pay for aggregated, anonymized data to optimize course offerings and improve employment outcomes.
3. **Targeted Ads & Partnerships:**
    - Specialized schools, certification providers, and training institutions pay for ad placements and promotional listings.
4. **Premium Personal Plans:**
    - For alumni and young professionals no longer linked to institutions (PHP 99/month) for continuous access to career recommendations and tracking tools.

5.1 Capital Outlay

Expense Category	Year 1 (PHP)	Year 2 (PHP)	Year 3 (PHP)
Development Team + QA	900000	700000	600000
Hosting & Security	120000	150000	200000
Legal & Data Compliance	100000	100000	120000
UX/UI Design	80000	50000	50000
Marketing & School Outreach	150000	300000	400000
Operations & Admin	200000	250000	300000
Customer Support	100000	150000	200000
Platform Maintenance	80000	120000	150000
Contingency Fund	70000	80000	100000

5.2 3 - Year Financial Projection

Year	Revenue	Expenses	Net Profit
Y1	₱0	₱1.35M	-₱1.35M
Y2	₱1.8M	₱1.2M	₱600,000
Y3	₱5.5M	₱2.5M	₱3M

TECHNOLOGY INNOVATION

Technology Stack

- **AI-Powered Career Recommendation Engine:** Uses machine learning algorithms similar to Spotify's recommendation model, analyzing user profiles, skills, certifications, dream job, and dream company to create personalized career pathways.
- **API Integrations:** Connects with job boards, certification providers (TESDA, Coursera), and school LMS systems to automate data flow and expand career options for students.
- **Data Analytics Dashboard:** Provides institutions with real-time aggregated data on student career aspirations, employability trends, and skills gaps to improve curriculum planning.
- **Secure Cloud Infrastructure:** Hosted on AWS or Google Cloud, ensuring high availability, data privacy, and compliance with the Philippine Data Privacy Act.
- **Adaptive UI/UX:** Mobile-first, responsive web platform with future iterations for native iOS and Android applications.

Emerging Technologies Used

- **Machine Learning (ML):** Recommendation engine uses collaborative filtering and content-based filtering to suggest optimal skills, certifications, and job paths.
- **Natural Language Processing (NLP):** Parses job descriptions and user inputs to refine recommendations and identify skill gaps.
- **Data Anonymization Algorithms:** Ensure privacy and compliance when aggregating student data for institutional reports.
- **API-Driven Architecture:** Enables scalable integrations with future partners (schools, employers, government job portals).

Market Disruption Potential

- **First-of-its-Kind in the Philippines:** No existing platform provides a personalized, data-driven career roadmap from senior high school to early professional stages.
- **Bridges the Education-to-Employment Gap:** Moves beyond job listings to intelligent, actionable guidance for students and institutions.
- **Scalable Across SEA:** Technology stack is designed for multi-institution, multilingual, and multi-country expansion.

MVP & ITERATIONS

MVP Features:

- Student onboarding with personal and career goal data.
- Basic recommendations engine with top 5 skills/certifications to reach target job.
- Simple dashboard for students and initial analytics for schools.

Iteration 1:

- Skill gap analyzer: "What am I missing to reach my dream job?"
- Output: Courses or experiences that improve readiness
- Addition of dark mode, improved UI.
- Expanded recommendations based on additional data points (e.g., personality traits, extracurriculars).

Iteration 2:

- Visual roadmap with milestone tracking, calendar sync
- Notifications for new job postings or certifications

- AI-powered mock interview preparation tool.
- Integration with job boards and real-time job market trends.

PITCH DECK OVERVIEW

Slide Breakdown:

1. Problem
2. Solution (Demo GIF or screenshots)
3. Market Size
4. Business Model
5. Growth Strategy
6. Revenue Forecast
7. Team + Traction
8. Call to Action

CONCLUSION

This innovation report proposes a scalable, high-impact career recommendation platform that bridges students, schools, and future employers. It addresses systemic employment challenges in the Philippines using emerging technologies. With sustainable revenue and aligned institutional interests, it is poised to become a transformative tool in education-to-employment pathways.

TEAM AND ROLES

The project was developed by a four-member team, each contributing their unique expertise in development, design, and documentation. The collaborative effort ensured that both the technical prototype and strategic framework were delivered on time and aligned with the goals of Technopreneurship 2.

7.1 Team Members and Responsibilities

Project Leader / Coordinator
Name: Ian Roncesvalles
Role: Managed the project timeline, delegated tasks, and led team coordination. Oversaw all outputs and ensure alignment with course deliverables.
Key Contribution:

- Supervised the overall direction of the Nextep project
- Led group meetings and managed internal deadlines
- Ensured alignment between prototype, paper, and presentation
- Consolidated final documentation and submissions

Documenter / UI Designer
Name: Amanda Mangubat
Role: Designed the UI/UX flow of the prototype and created the official documentation and slide materials.
Key Contribution:

- Developed the visual design of the tracker, forms, and sidebar
- Prepared and formatted the written paper
- Contributed to the Business Model Canvas and financial sections
- Assisted in writing system descriptions and user flow
- Prepare reports, presentations, and official documentation.

- Conduct competitor and market analysis for strategic positioning.
- Lead marketing campaigns to promote Nextep to schools and students.
- Collect user feedback and translate findings into product improvement suggestions.

Prototype Developer / Frontend Support
Name: Ken Escolar
Role: Coded the job tracker interface and key prototype components, ensuring visual accuracy based on design.
Key Contribution:
- Built the core interface including tracker columns and cards
- Assisted in form functionality and design integration
- Collaborated in shaping the technical stack for scalability
- Provided screenshots and assets for final documentation

Prototype Developer / Backend Planner
Name: Arzad Mariano
Role: Supported the development of functional elements and helped plan the system architecture and logic.
Key Contribution:
- Implemented logic for form fields, card movement, and task interaction
- Collaborated on platform security and data handling plans
- Helped align UI features with backend feasibility
- Co-developed content for the Technology Innovation section

REFERENCES AND APPENDICES

Appendices

- Grok: App Development Tool
- Prototype Screenshots (Figma)
- Financial spreadsheet (CSV or Sheets)
- CIIT Interview Protocol
- Market Survey Draft
- Sample API Dashboard Output

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Income Statement Year 1-3

Category	Year 1 (PHP)	Year 2 (PHP)	Year 3 (PHP)
Revenue	0	1800000	5500000
COGS (Hosting, Infra, Licenses)	0	200000	400000
Gross Profit	0	1600000	5100000
Operating Expenses			
Salaries and Dev Team	800000	900000	1200000
Marketing and Outreach	100000	200000	500000
Legal & Compliance	100000	100000	150000
Office/Admin Expenses	50000	70000	150000
Total Operating Expenses	1050000	1270000	2000000
Operating Profit (EBIT)	-1050000	330000	3100000
Taxes (30%)	0	99000	930000
Net Income	-1050000	231000	2170000